

L^AT_EX for Elegant Humanities Handouts in Conferences and Classrooms

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About me

I serve as Lecturer in Religious Studies at the University of Houston, course developer and instructor in the Th.D. program at St. Leo University, and instructor of Catholic theology in the core curriculum at the University of St. Thomas in Texas.

Broadly, I study patristics (the Church Fathers) and the theology of the Latin Middle Ages and Greek Byzantium. My research topics include Greek patristic Christology and cosmology, plus their Latin Scholastic reception. I am the author of *Maximus the Confessor's Thomistic Legacy* (Pontifical Institute of Mediæval Studies: Toronto, 2026).

I advocate software freedom by delivering talks like this one.

For more about my work, visit coreystephan.com.

L^AT_EX beyond its normal bounds

The world's best established software system for typesetting and document formatting, L^AT_EX has been popular throughout mathematical and physical sciences for decades.

The utility of L^AT_EX for humanities disciplines, however, tends to be overlooked.

L^AT_EX can be used for typesetting in most instances in which a scholar of humanities needs to present her materials.

I prepared these slides in L^AT_EX – with less frustration than I would have had with a graphical presentation program – as 1 file:

github.com/historical-theology/latex-talks/blob/main/tug/humanities-latex.tex

Today's tutorial

In this tutorial, I will introduce attendees to the use of L^AT_EX for a common task in humanities scholarship, namely,

typesetting texts with unusual line length and other organizational needs, such as primary texts with accompanying translations.

The ‘thought experiment’ will be that of determining how to prepare a handout for a historical conference or class presentation with perfectly organized excerpts of a Byzantine Greek text and an original English translation in parallel.

As a humanities scholar, why choose L^AT_EX? (1/2)

I intend this and other general explanations of L^AT_EX and its usage that I provide to be for the benefit of my colleagues who might view this presentation online.

In humanities disciplines, such as my own area of historical theology, editors expect us to prepare our materials for publications with bug-for-bug compatibility with Microsoft Word for back-and-forth markup. In practice, this expectation requires us to use word processors, such as (my favorite option) LibreOffice Writer.

A **word processor** presents material in a **What You See Is What You Get** (**WYSIWYG**, “whizzy-wig”) style. While one writes, one is simultaneously thinking about and working on formatting.

As a humanities scholar, why choose L^AT_EX? (2/2)

In a **typesetting language**, such as L^AT_EX (or ConT_EXt or Typst, either of which a humanities scholar might also choose for various reasons), one is only concerned about the *structure* of what one is writing.

One declares that specific characters will be in certain categories of writing ‘things’ (heading, paragraph, footnote, accent type, typeface, etc.), and one allows the program to compile one’s writing as ‘code’ into a tidy final document – every time.

Preparing a *curriculum vitae*, conference handout, or other document with unusual typesetting requirements becomes about the writing itself rather than the formatting.

Learning L^AT_EX as a scholar in the humanities

2 community-built, libre guidebooks

The Not So Short Introduction to L^AT_EX

github.com/oetiker/lshort

Modern L^AT_EX

github.com/mrkline/modern-latex

Either guidebook may be used to begin to learn how to typeset prose, letters, ancient languages, and other materials that are relevant across the humanities – without the strong front-loading of mathematics and physical sciences that one finds in other introductions to L^AT_EX.

In other words, either option provides an efficient introduction to L^AT_EX for a scholar in a humanities discipline.

Simple setting of parallel text in L^AT_EX

There are many ways to set parallel text in L^AT_EX.

The simplest is to use the community package called **parallel**, which is included in T_EX Live, MiK_TE_X, and other L^AT_EX distributions. For full documentation, visit:

ctan.org/pkg/parallel

To start using **parallel** in any L^AT_EX document, include the following in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{parallel}
```


Using the *parallel* package (1/2)

Basic format

```
\begin{Parallel}{}{< left adjustment >}{< right adjustment >}  
    \ParallelLText{< left text row 1 >}  
    \ParallelRText{< right text row 1 >}  
    \ParallelPar  
    \ParallelLText{< left text row 2 >}  
    [and so on]  
\end{Parallel}
```

Using the *parallel* package (2/2)

Example

```
\begin{Parallel}{0mm}{0mm}  
  \ParallelLText{Ave Maria ,}  
  \ParallelRText{Hail Mary ,}  
  \ParallelPar  
  \ParallelLText{gratia plena ,}  
  \ParallelRText{full of grace ,}  
  \ParallelPar  
  \ParallelLText{\ldots}  
  \ParallelRText{\ldots}  
\end{Parallel}
```

Ave Maria,
gratia plena,
...

Hail Mary,
full of grace,
...

Advanced setting of parallel text in L^AT_EX (1/2)

For advanced scholarly setting of parallel text in L^AT_EX, especially long-form (e.g. a critical edition with accompanying translation), one ought to learn the two interconnected and frequently updated community packages

reledpar (for parallel typesetting specifically) and

reledmac (for typesetting academic editions in general),

which are bundled with T_EX Live and other L^AT_EX distributions.

reledpar and **reledmac** are purpose-built for long-form academic parallel texts.

These two packages are meant to replace older methods of academic parallel text preparation in L^AT_EX that one might find in Web searches.

Advanced setting of parallel text in L^AT_EX (2/2)

For full documentation, visit:

[ctan.org/pkg/**reledpar**](http://ctan.org/pkg/reledpar)

[ctan.org/pkg/**reledmac**](http://ctan.org/pkg/reledmac)

To start using **reledpar** and **reledmac**, remember them in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{reledpar}
```

```
\usepackage{reledmac}
```

Setting of non-Latin text in L^AT_EX

The most important packages for handling text outside of Latin alphabets are the community packages **babel** and **polyglossia**, which are included in T_EX Live and other L^AT_EX distributions.

Although it is possible to convert a project from one of these metapackages to the other, one ought to invest the time to choose carefully between either of these two at the start of a long-form project.

polyglossia vs. babel (1/2)

In *The L^AT_EX Companion: 3rd Edition*, Frank Mittelbach and Ulrike Fischer, both of whom are fellow speakers at TUG 2026, suggest that despite the fact that **babel** is older than **polyglossia**,

babel generally is preferable:

“Unless you are in a special situation where a language or script is notably better supported by **polyglossia**, the recommendation is to use **babel** with all engines” (entry 13.7.2, “Polyglossia”).

Since **babel** technically supports the same languages as **polyglossia**, a situation in which one would need **polyglossia** over **babel** will be rare, but a scholar working with ancient languages might have such a rare situation.

polyglossia vs. babel (2/2)

In (old) web forum discussions, one might read that **babel** will work better with Lua $\TeX$, whereas **polyglossia** will work better with X $\TeX$.

In 2026, however, one can choose either **babel** or **polyglossia** for either of the two mainline $\TeX$ engines that are built with full Unicode support, X $\TeX$ or Lua $\TeX$.

Results might vary depending on the specifics of a given project.

(I typically use Lua $\TeX$ to compile **polyglossia**, including for these slides.)

To make an informed choice, one should explore each package's documentation:

ctan.org/pkg/babel

ctan.org/pkg/polyglossia

To learn **babel**, I recommend Chapter 13: “Localizing documents” in *The LaTeX Companion: 3rd Edition* by Mittelbach and Fischer,

which succinctly introduces localization in LaTeX via **babel** in a practical, didactic (teaching) style, that is,

pages 297–342, in Mittelbach, Frank, and Ulrike Fischer. *The LaTeX Companion: Third Edition - Part II*. Addison-Wesley, 2023.

Learning polyglossia

To learn **polyglossia**, I recommend the package's official documentation, that is,

ctan.org/pkg/polyglossia

Starting a project with *polyglossia*

Here, I will model **polyglossia**, which is what I happen to be familiar with using for polytonic (ancient and Byzantine) Greek. (Yet, after reading the recommendation of Mittelbach and Fischer, I intend to try **babel** for future projects.)

Include the package in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{polyglossia}
```

Then, *after* the beginning of the document but *before* actual type, declare the languages and their variants. For example, here is this .tex file's polyglossia declarations:

```
\begin{document}  
\setdefaultlanguage{english}  
\setotherlanguage[variant=ancient]{greek}
```

When using one of the ‘other’ declared languages, toggle it when needed.

A language may be toggled for a long excerpt like so:¹

```
\begin{greek}
<greek text>
```

```
...
\end{greek}
```

```
\begin{greek} ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος
    , \ \ καὶ ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν
    , \ \ καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος
    . \ \
\end{greek}
```

ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος,
 καὶ ὁ λόγος ἦν πρὸς τὸν θεόν,
 καὶ θεὸς ἦν ὁ λόγος.

¹Here and in other code samples, the Greek text is spaced incorrectly due to a limitation of using the package `lstlisting`

A language may be toggled for a single line like so:

```
\text<language>\{<text in language>\}
```

e.g.

```
\textgreek\{<Greek text>\}
```

This might be used to insert a keyword, e.g.
ὁ λόγος (produced with `\textgreek{ὁ λόγος}`),
inside prose.

Combining *parallel* and *polyglossia*

The simplest way of showing multilingual text in parallel is

```
\begin{Parallel}{0mm}{0mm}  
  \text<language>{\ParallelLText{<ancient text 1>}}  
  \ParallelRText{<modern text>}  
  \ParallelPar  
  \text<language>{\ParallelLText{<ancient text 2>}}  
  \ParallelRText{<modern text 2>}  
\end{Parallel}
```

but since this is tedious for more than a few lines, I remind everyone of **reledpar** and **reledmac** for longer and/or more complicated parallel text displays.

Here is a simple example of **parallel** and **polyglossia** working in combination to display my own translation from the opening chapter of *Maximus the Confessor's Thomistic Legacy*:

```

\begin{Parallel}{0mm}{0mm}
  \textgreek{\ParallelLTextΝῦν{ συγχορεύειςἀληθῶς }}
  \ParallelRText{Now, truly, you celebrate together}
  \ParallelPar
  \textgreek{\ParallelLTextσὺν{ τοῖςλοιποῖςθεολόγοις }}
  \ParallelRText{with the rest of the theologians}
  ...
\end{Parallel}

```

For a conference or classroom handout, the result might look like the next slide:

Canon in Honor of Thomas Aquinas, Ode 3²

Translated by Corey Stephan, Ph.D.

Νῦν συγχορεύεις ἀληθῶς
σὺν τοῖς λοιποῖς θεολόγοις
καὶ τοῖς ἄλλοις θεολήπτοις ἀνδράσι,
περὶ τὸν θρόνον Χριστοῦ
τὸν ἱερὸν ἐξάδοντες
καὶ τρισάγιον ὕμνον
σὺν ταῖς ἀγίαις δυνάμεσιν.

Ἐνθα πατέρων ὁ χορὸς
καὶ ἱερῶν θεολόγων
ὥς ὑψίνους καὶ λεπτὸς θεόλογος
κατεσκήνωσας, Θωμᾶ,
σὺν τούτοις ἀυλιζόμενος,
θεολογῶν ἀπαύστως
τριάδα, πάτερ, τὴν ἄκτιστον.

Now, truly, you celebrate together
with the rest of the theologians
and the other divinely inspired men
around the throne of Christ,
singing the sacred
and Thrice-Holy Hymn
with the holy powers.

Where there is the chorus of Fathers
and holy theologians,
as a high-minded and subtle theologian
you do abide, Thomas,
dwelling with them,
unceasingly theologizing,
O Father, about the Uncreated Trinity.

²The Greek text is from Raffaele Cantarella, ed., “Canone greco inedito di Giuseppe vescovo di Methone in onore di San Tommaso d’Aquino,” *Archivum Fratrum Praedicatorum* 12 (1934): 145–85, at 155–58.

Other $\text{\LaTeX}$ Tools for Scholars

BibLaTeX – comprehensive citation and bibliography management, capable of being interlinked with a variety of citation managers (notably, Zotero and JabRef).

TeXstudio and other $\text{\LaTeX}$ -specific graphical writing environments

LaTeX can be written in any plain text editor, but a designated environment improves efficiency and helps avoid code errors.

Designated packages for individual languages, e.g. **Serto** for Syriac

See Chapter 13 of *The $\text{\LaTeX}$ Companion: Third Edition* for other recommendations for language-specific package options, or run search queries in CTAN.

microtype for small adjustments to type, such as improved automatic hyphenation

I thank the organizers of TUG 2026.

Now, I will take questions, comments, suggestions, and more.